



The Principles You Already Signed

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 To the architects and city planners now under pressure to build, and build fast: this is not written to slow you down. The shortage is real. The United States is short roughly 3.5 to 4 million homes as of 2024, a gap the National Association of Home Builders and the Urban Institute have tracked across boom and bust alike, and in most metro areas median rent has climbed at twice the pace of median wages over the past decade, so that more than 50 million households, about one in three, now spend past the federal benchmark of 30 percent of income just to stay housed. No one who has read those figures wants you idle. The pressure to add units is not a distortion of your duty. It is your duty.

2 But it is not the whole of it, and you said so first. When you adopted the Charter of the New Urbanism in 1996, you committed your profession to walkability, to mixed-use neighborhoods, to streets built at human scale; when the American Institute of Architects bound its members to safeguard the health, safety, and welfare of the public and to work toward an improved quality of life; when you taught a generation to design for the eight-year-old and the eighty-year-old on the theory that a street good for both is good for everyone, you set down a standard that a tally of finished units cannot, by itself, satisfy. The Project for Public Spaces calls the same thing placemaking. You have many names for it.

3 I grant that you did not write the zoning codes that restrict apartments across most of the country, nor the financing rules that reward unit count over the public realm, nor the cost pressures that turn a ground floor meant for a shop into one more wall. These are real, and they are not chiefly yours. Still, the research your own bodies publish is hard to set aside. The Urban Land Institute and the American Planning Association find that moderate density, somewhere around 15 to 25 homes an acre in walkable settings, can lower per-unit cost and hold livability at once; the same literature finds that residents of such places drive less and walk more, which trims their transportation bills and, the public-health work suggests, their isolation. Density and human scale are not opposed. The work says you can have both.

4 Amsterdam manages it. Barcelona manages it. Greenwich Village, blocks of it, has managed it for a century. What those places share is not a magic number of stories but a street that does something at eye level: a plaza, a doorway, a shop you can walk into. Duany and Plater-Zyberk argued a quarter century ago that sprawl was not an accident but the result of abandoning exactly that, and the profession largely agreed. The harder admission, which your own journals have started to make, is that density can fail the same test from the other direction. A tower with a blank base adds homes and subtracts a neighborhood. Occupied is not the same as alive.

5 So I will not ask you to choose livability over housing, because that is the false choice your own scholarship rejects, and I will not ask you to ignore a crisis that costs one in three households more than

they can spare. I ask something narrower and, I think, fairer. When the next pro forma comes back and the ground floor is the line item easiest to cut, hold it to the charter you signed. Build the homes. Build them so a child and an old woman would both want to be on the street outside. That part was always the assignment. You wrote it down.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer concedes that architects did not author the zoning codes, financing rules, or cost pressures primarily in order to
 - A) grant the opposing reality its real force so that the appeal to the profession's own research reads as fair rather than accusatory
 - B) establish that the profession bears no responsibility for the housing crisis and should be left alone
 - C) shift the argument toward reforming municipal zoning law as the only workable solution
 - D) demonstrate that the writer possesses technical command of development finance
2. The short sentence "Occupied is not the same as alive" at the end of the fourth paragraph primarily serves to
 - A) accuse developers of deliberately building uninhabitable housing
 - B) soften the preceding criticism of towers by conceding their practical usefulness
 - C) compress the paragraph's point about density without street-level life into a flat, memorable contrast
 - D) introduce a new statistic about vacancy rates in high-density buildings

Discussion questions:

1. The letter spends its entire first paragraph granting the urgency of the housing crisis before it raises a single objection. How does conceding so much ground early change the way you receive the request in the final paragraph? Would the appeal be more or less persuasive if it opened with the criticism instead?
2. The writer repeatedly holds architects to standards architects themselves established (the 1996 Charter, the AIA code of ethics, the 8-80 principle) rather than to standards the writer invents. Why might borrowed authority be more effective here than the writer asserting their own view of what good design requires?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The letter argues that adding housing units and preserving human-scale, livable streets are not opposing goals but obligations a profession can meet at once. Drawing on your own observation, reading, and experience, write an essay that argues the extent to which you agree or disagree with the claim that communities can pursue density and livability together without sacrificing one for the other. Develop your position with specific, relevant evidence, and consider a perspective different from your own.